

August 13, 2026

TRICARE East (Humana Military)
Provider Appeals Department

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Marlin Kuphal (MRN MUSC4410722), Claim MUSC-3CE3-1

Patient	Marlin Kuphal (DOB 1941-08-11)
MRN	MUSC4410722
Member ID / Group	TRI659593889 / GRP-81211
Claim number	MUSC-3CE3-1
Date of service	2026-05-01
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$440.71
Denial code	CARC 16 / RARC N290 — Claim/service lacks information or has submission/billing error(s).
Appeal deadline	2026-08-24

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health is submitting this formal first-level appeal on behalf of Marlin Kuphal (Member ID: TRI659593889, MRN: MUSC4410722, Date of Birth: August 11, 1941) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-3CE3-1 for services rendered on May 1, 2026, at MUSC Health East Cooper Medical Center in Mount Pleasant, South Carolina. The claim was denied on May 26, 2026, under CARC 16 / RARC N290, with the payer remark stating: "Claim cannot be adjudicated; required data element(s) are missing or invalid," specifically citing a missing, incomplete, or invalid rendering provider primary identifier. MUSC Health respectfully disputes this denial and submits that the rendering provider's National Provider Identifier (NPI) was valid and present at the time of submission, and requests immediate reprocessing and payment of the claim.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Mr. Kuphal is an 85-year-old established male patient with a documented history of chronic sinusitis with onset dating to 1977 and longstanding hypertension managed with Hydrochlorothiazide, active since 1959. On May 1, 2026, he presented to MUSC Health East Cooper Medical Center for an outpatient encounter billed under CPT 99214, representing an office or outpatient visit for an established patient of moderate complexity. The primary diagnosis recorded was J06.9 (Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified), with a secondary diagnosis of I10 (Essential hypertension). The visit was conducted by Elena V. Castellanos, MD, NPI 1881726354, at a place of service designated as 22 (On Campus Outpatient Hospital). The total billed amount was \$440.71, against an allowed amount of \$270.98. No payment was issued.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial under RARC N290 asserts that the rendering provider's primary identifier was missing, incomplete, or invalid. MUSC Health maintains that this characterization is incorrect. Dr. Elena V. Castellanos holds an active NPI of 1881726354, which is a valid Type 1 individual NPI registered in the National Plan and Provider Enumeration System (NPES). This NPI was included on the claim as submitted on May 12, 2026. TRICARE and its contracted administrator, Humana Military, are required under HIPAA transaction and code set standards to accept a valid NPI as the primary provider identifier on electronic claims. If a data element was flagged as invalid during processing, MUSC Health respectfully requests that TRICARE East identify the specific field or format discrepancy that triggered the edit, as the provider information on file is accurate and verifiable through NPES. No clinical or medical necessity issue has been raised by the payer; the sole stated basis for denial is an administrative data element concern, which is correctable and does not reflect any deficiency in the care provided or the appropriateness of the services billed. MUSC Health is prepared to resubmit a corrected claim if the payer can identify the precise formatting requirement that was not met, but notes that the NPI as submitted is valid on its face.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that TRICARE East (Humana Military) reopen and reprocess Claim MUSC-3CE3-1 in full, applying the allowed amount of \$270.98 and issuing payment accordingly. Should the payer identify a specific data element or formatting deficiency that prevented adjudication, we request written notification of that deficiency so that a corrected claim may be submitted without delay. This appeal is being filed within the 90-day appeal window, prior to the stated deadline of August 24, 2026. MUSC Health remains committed to resolving this matter promptly and cooperatively, and asks that the payer provide a written determination in accordance with TRICARE's applicable appeal response timeframe requirements.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record